The Christology of Divine Identity between Paul and the Quran

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1. Introduction

The deity of Jesus has been a point of controversy for Muslims since the very earliest expressions of the Islamic faith. One of the consequences of that disagreement has been the development of a decidedly negative narrative about the Apostle Paul in Muslim tradition. A central contention in many influential Islamic writings about Paul is that Paul perverted the original Islam-like monotheism of the followers of Jesus by inventing and teaching the doctrines that Jesus is divine, the Son of God, and a member of the Trinity with God and Mary (Stern 1968, 179-80; van Koningsveld 1996, 203-8, 211, 213-14, 216; Anthony 2010, 194, 199; Barzegar 2011, 217, 226: Kuhn 2018, 150, 153-4, 157-160, 168-9).

The negative Islamic narrative about Paul persists even today on popular platforms such as YouTube and social media, where it is used in a polemical manner. When one compares this negative Islamic narrative with the writings by and about Paul in the New Testament, however, one finds not only a strikingly different story about the man, but also an explanation of the deity of Jesus in the context of the strongest monotheism of his time. Paul's explanation could be seen to anticipate Islamic denials of Jesus' deity understood from the Quran and developed in the doctrine of *tawḥīd*. Or, put another way, one might imagine how the New Testament Paul would have responded to denials of the deity of Jesus in the Quran.

This essay will not delve into the various fascinating details of the traditional Muslim characterizations of Paul, but will rather attempt to bring the New Testament writings of Paul into a kind of conversation with Quranic passages that appear to distinguish the Muslim scripture's concept of monotheism from perceived Christian beliefs about the identity of Jesus. Muslim theological understandings of those Quranic passages will in turn be brought in from the Islamic interpretive tradition (*tafsīr*), including from the earliest complete commentary on the Quran by Muqātil ibn Sulaymān (d. 767).

Among the earliest dated written expressions of Islamic faith are the texts which the Muslim conquerors of Jerusalem chose to feature in the Dome of the Rock in 691 (Lazarus-Yafeh 1996, 69; de Prémare 2007, 179; cf. Kessler 1970, 12-13). The majority of these texts appears to address the identity of Jesus, here called ʿĪsā (Nickel 2017, 288). In their Quranic versions these verses were interpreted as such by Muslim commentators. Key among them and inscribed several times is Sūra 112, with its declaration that Allah is one and its denial of divine begetting or being begotten. Other inscribed verses address and deny the statement that Allah "has taken a son" (Q 17:111; 4:171-2; 19:35). Christel Kessler characterized the featured Dome texts as "the holy verses which proclaim and safeguard God's indivisible unity" (Kessler 1970, 12).

This exploration, however, will start with the key characteristics of the divine identity in Second Temple Jewish monotheism and how Paul and the early Christians came to understand Jesus to be included in that identity. Jewish monotheism clearly distinguished the one God from all other reality, and early Christians consciously stood in this tradition, but this did not stop from understanding Jesus deliberately on the divine side of that divide (Bauckham 2008, 3-4). How they did so is something of great relevance to the dialogue between Christians and Muslims about who God is.

2. Second Temple Jewish monotheism

A missing element in the Quranic denials of the deity of Jesus and in the subsequent Islamic accusations against the Apostle Paul is a familiarity with the theological context of Second Temple Judaism. The earliest Christian reflection on the identity of Jesus came out of a background of exegesis of the Hebrew Bible. Early Christians, including Paul, wrote in the context of the vast Jewish literature of the period.

An avenue into this material is provided by Richard Bauckham's description of Second Temple Jewish monotheism and his thesis for how the development of New Testament Christology fits into that context. Bauckham presented his thesis in broad terms in a 1998 publication titled *God Crucified: Monotheism and Christology in the New Testament*, then focused Paul's role in this development in the essay "Paul's Christology of divine identity" (2008, 182-232). He has written similar surveys of the Christology of other New Testament writings such as the Letter to the

Hebrews (2008, 233-53) and the Gospel according to John (2007, 239-52), and has also presented on New Testament monotheism and Christology in the context of Christian-Muslim dialogue (2018).[1]

Judaism during the Second Temple period (ca. 516 B.C. to 70 A.D.) held to a strict monotheism (Bauckham 2008, 1-17, 182). Most Jews of the period shared well-known beliefs about the identity of God and distinguished sharply between God and all other reality. They showed these beliefs in the central position they gave to such texts as Deuteronomy 6:4-6 (the *Shemaʿ*) and Exodus 20:2-6 (the part of the Decalogue that forbids worship of any gods but YHWH).

Bauckham argues that theological discourse in Second Temple Judaism addressed the identity of God ("Who is God?") rather than the nature of divinity ("What is God?"). The nature of divinity, defined by Greek philosophy during this period according to a series of metaphysical attributes, was less important to Jewish writers. Jewish writers characterized God's identity mostly in ways other than metaphysical attributes.

God revealed himself to Israel by the name YHWH, a precise indication of God's own identity. Israel understood God's identity through his actions in guiding and saving them, particularly in the Exodus, and his character through texts such as Exodus 34:6.

When characterizing God's relationship to all of creation, Second Temple Judaism emphasized the identity of God as the sole Creator of all things and the only sovereign Ruler of all things. For this reason, they also considered the God of Israel to be worthy of worship. "Worship, in the Jewish tradition, is recognition of the unique divine identity" (Bauckham 2008, 18). Any so-called "intermediary figures" were unambiguously considered to be creatures unless they were presented in Hebrew scripture as aspects of the one God's unique identity (e.g. God's Wisdom and God's Word) (Bauckham 2008, 182).

Looking ahead to the possible implications of this scholarship for Christian-Muslim conversation about the deity of Jesus, one must already question the Muslim accusation that Paul perverted the

[1] The description of Bauckham's "Christology of divine identity" in this article is not presented as the final word on interpretation of the relevant New Testament texts, but rather simply as a coherent and meticulously-argued thesis that creates space for Christian-Muslim conversation about the deity of Jesus and the role of Paul in its articulation. Bauckham freely indicates and interacts with scholarly perspectives which do not share his conclusions at the same time as he also brings in supporting scholarship.

monotheism of the early Christians. Also, a more careful description of types of monotheism is required. Though Judaism in the period when Paul wrote was "pervasively, self-consciously and strictly monotheistic" (Bauckham 2008, 18), one should not assume that this Second Temple Jewish monotheism was the same as the monotheism of the Quran and Islamic commentary just because they share the same English term. That would be like claiming that because the Hebrew word *'eḥād* ("one") in Deuteronomy 6:4 has the same semitic root letters as the Arabic *'aḥad* ("one") in Sūra 112:1, they must represent the same concept of divine oneness. In between is Paul who, we shall see below, understood the "one" of Deut 6:4 quite differently from how Muslims interpreted the "one" of Sūra 112:1.

3. Early Christian christological monotheism

This Second Temple Jewish monotheism was the theological context for early Church reflection on the identity of Jesus, including the writings of Paul, according to Bauckham (2008, 18-31, 184-218). It was the strongest monotheism of its time: "Before the advent of Christianity, Judaism was unique among the religions of the Roman world in demanding the exclusive worship of its God" (Bauckham 2008, 140).

The first Christians looked to texts from the Pentateuch, the Psalms, and Isaiah to account for what they had seen or heard about in Jesus. The witnesses of Jesus' life, crucifixion and resurrection needed to find a way of expressing what had happened and who Jesus was. The text that they referred to more than any other was Psalm 110:1, "The LORD says to my lord: 'Sit at my right hand, till I make your enemies your footstool.'" From Isaiah, the early Christians especially treasured chapters 40-55, with its ringing affirmations of one God and no other (e.g. Isaiah 43:11; 44:5, 6, 21, 22; 45:5; 46:9) (Bauckham 2008, 33-7).

The way they took was to identify Jesus with that one God of the Hebrew scriptures. The New Testament writers did not write about the deity of Jesus in opposition to the monotheism of Second Temple Judaism, but rather wrote about Jesus' deity explicitly in the terms of the identity of God in that very monotheism. If fact, the texts they used from the Old Testament themselves frequently declared the oneness of God or contained such declarations in the close context (2008, 191). New Testament writers affirmed Jesus' participation in the divine sovereignty over all

things and in the creation of all things. They identified Jesus by the divine name YHWH and asserted that he deserves the worship that is recognition of the unique divine identity (Bauckham 2008, 19).

Paul's writings are notable for the number of times he identified the YHWH of key Hebrew Bible passages with Jesus Christ (Bauckham 2008, 186-91). Many of these passages would have been read by Paul as expressions of eschatological monotheism. Paul used the word "God" for Jesus in comparatively few places. Interestingly, Bauckham suggests that because "YHWH" names the unique identity of God, it "is exclusive to the one God in a way that the sometimes ambiguous word 'god' is not" (2008, 200).

Consideration of Bauckham's thesis and the biblical texts he claims for evidence leads to many fascinating thoughts with Islam in mind. Perhaps most striking of all is the timeline that Bauckham proposes for the development of a Christology of divine identity. Islam has generally resisted all thoughts of such a Christology and, in the diverse Islamic traditions about Paul, has imagined an indeterminate time gap between the purported original *tawḥīd*-like monotheism of the first followers (or disciples, *hawāriyyūn*, Q 3:52) of Jesus and the alleged perversions of Paul (Stern 1968, 178-81; van Koningsvelt 1996, 203-8; Anthony 2010, 173-80; Barzegar 2011, 217-18; Kuhn 2018, 153-4, 157-8). Bauckham asserts to the contrary (however, without any apparent application to Islam), "...the highest possible Christology – the inclusion of Jesus in the unique divine identity – was central to the faith of the early church even before any of the New Testament writings were written, since it occurs in all of them" (2008, 19).

Bauckham writes that the authors of the New Testament did not consider their identifications of Jesus with the divine identity to contradict the Jewish monotheism of their Second Temple context. "The New Testament writers did not see their Jewish monotheistic heritage as in any way an obstacle to the inclusion of Jesus in the divine identity" (2008, 19). This kind of assertion of course works against the Islamic tradition that it was Paul who introduced this teaching to pervert the original faith.

Another issue is the dominance in classical Muslim commentary of much later Patristic discussions of how to explain the deity of Jesus in Greek. Some of the academic scholarship on Islam, in an effort to account for the portrayal of Christian belief in the deity of Jesus in the Quran and Muslim *tafsīr*, appeal to the concepts and terminology of the Ecumenical Councils of

Nicea (325) and Chalcedon (451). For example, Michel Cuypers describes how Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī (d. 1209) and Jaᶜfar Muḥammad ibn Jarīr al-Ṭabarī (d. 923) showed familiarity with terms like "substance" and "hypostases" in their interpretations of passages such as Sūra 5:72-7 (Cuypers 2009, 339). The important point to understand about Paul's writing on Jesus' deity is that he was not writing out of this much later Greek – and largely non-Jewish – Christian context, but rather as a Second Temple Jew with the Hebrew Bible in mind. It is familiarity with this first-century Hebrew Bible context for the Christology of divine identity, and with the book of Isaiah and early Christian understandings, perhaps even the knowledge that all the earliest Christians were Jews, that is apparently missing from both Quran and Islamic commentary.

Bauckhamᶜs vocabulary for the development of early Christian christological monotheism in the writings of Paul and other New Testament writers is the language of understanding, identifying, including, incorporating, sharing, belonging, participating in, etc. The Quranic vocabulary for what it conceives of Christians doing with ᶜIsā is largely limited to forms of the verb *ashraka* (*shirk*, *sharīk*, *mushrik*) meaning "to associate" (e.g. Q 3:64, 5:72, 9:31; cf. 17:111, 23:91-92, 25:2). In Muslim thought the sin of *shirk* is one of the most serious and its punishments are extensive (e.g. Q 4:49; 9:5, 33, 36, 113). To understand Paul authentically and to imagine what he might bring into a conversation with Islam about the deity of Jesus, one must avoid taking the Islamic characterization of his actions for what he actually did in the context of Second Temple Judaism.

Further thoughts with Islam in mind related to Christology in Quran and *tafsīr* and Muslim traditions about Paul are presented below according to the key points of the divine identity that early Christians understood in Jesus.

4. Eschatological monotheism

Bauckham calls Psalms 110:1 "the master text for the earliest Christology of divine identity" (2008, 198) because of widespread quotation of, and allusion to, the verse across the New Testament (2008, 21-22). Early Christians read the verse to mean that Jesus was placed on the divine throne and exercised sovereignty over all things. They understood from it the inclusion of

Jesus in the unique identity of God, and thus placed him on the divine side of the absolute distinction that separates the only Sovereign one from all else.

In the New Testament, this understanding of Psalms 110:1 among the earliest Christians circulated prior to the involvement of Paul. According to Acts 2, Peter's Pentecost sermon went straight from Jesus' crucifixion (v. 23) to his resurrection (vv. 24-32) to "Being therefore exalted at the right hand of God" (v. 33). Peter then quoted Psalm 110:1 (vv. 34-5), understanding that this verse would let his listeners "know assuredly that God has made him both Lord and Christ" (v. 36). Being exalted at the right hand of God is about Jesus' divine sovereignty, including – as Peter preached elsewhere – the right to give repentance and forgiveness of sins (Acts 5:31).

Paul shared the same understanding of Jesus' exaltation. In fact, in Philippians 2 Paul seems to have used what many scholars consider to be an established Christian confession to teach this. There he clearly highlights the exaltation of Jesus for his obedience unto death on the cross, drawing from an early Christian reading of Isaiah (esp. 52:13). Jesus exercises the uniquely divine sovereignty over all things and is given "the name which is above all names," which Bauckham argues must be YHWH (2008, 199).

Among the YHWH texts from the Hebrew Bible that Paul understands to refer to Jesus, many refer to "the final and universal manifestation of the unique identity of the one God" (Bauckham 2008, 193). The texts Paul used asserted not only the eschatological manifestation of the exclusive lordship of YHWH but also the eschatological salvation provided by YHWH (e.g. Joel 2:32 in Romans 10:9-13).

Quran and commentary

The concern for divine sovereignty appears in several of the Quranic texts that question the deity of Jesus, either explicitly or so understood in the Islamic interpretive tradition. Several of these texts approach the subject by means of response to the expression, "Allah has taken a son." Among these verses is Q 17:111, the text of which was inscribed inside the Dome of the Rock in 691 A.D. The verse denies that Allah has taken a son, then continues, "nor has he any associate in the kingdom, nor has he any [need of] an ally [to protect him] from disgrace."

The word here translated "kingdom," *mulk*, is also rendered as "rule," "dominion," and "sovereignty." Q 17:111 seems to oppose belief in a son of God by stating that Allah has no

associate (or "partner," *sharīk*) in sovereignty. A similar response to son of God comes at the end of the famous Q 4:171, with its many affirmations and denials about ʿĪsā: "To him [belongs] whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on the earth. Allah is sufficient as a guardian." Here the denial of divine sonship seems to be based on Allah's sole possession of the heavens and the earth. A third such verse, Q 10:68, repeats Allah's possession of the heavens and the earth and adds "He is the wealthy one," seeming to suggest that the idea of son of God threatens Allah's self-sufficiency.

Curiously, none of the Quranic verses that oppose the expression "Allah has taken a son (*walad*)" states explicitly who is claiming this belief.[2] However, similar Quranic responses come to another expression that occurs twice in the Quran, "Allah is the Messiah, the son of Mary" (Q 5:17, 72). Q 5:17 opposes this confession with the assertion, "Allah has the dominion (*mulk*) of the heavens and the earth and everything in them. He creates what he wills" (5:17). The same verse even proposes that Allah has the power (*yamliku*) to destroy both the Messiah and his mother, while 5:72 responds to the confession by putting on the lips of ʿĪsā a command to worship Allah. The verse characterizes stating the opposed expression as "associating with Allah," and the next verse quickly follows up with the declaration, "there is no god but one god" (5:73).

Out of the vast ocean of Muslim commentary on the Quran, many interpreters have dealt with the verses that proscribe the sovereignty of Allah. The *Tafsīr* of Muqātil ibn Sulayman is considered by many scholars to be the earliest complete commentary on the Quran (Nickel 2011, 30-34). If so, it provides understandings of the sovereignty verses from the formative period of Islam. At 5:17, Muqātil writes that it is the Jacobites (*Mar Yaʿqūbiyya*) who say "Allah is the Messiah," having attributed different confessions to the Nestorians and the Maronites at 5:15 (Muqātil 2002, I, 462-3). Allah shows his power over ʿĪsā by creating him without a father (I, 464).

In the longer passage of his interpretation of Q 5:72-77, Muqātil writes that those who continue to say "Allah is the Messiah" (v. 72) and "Allah is the third of three" (v. 73) are "associating" and for this will face the painful punishment of "killing by the sword and *jizya* on those who

[2] The explicit "The Christians say, 'The Messiah is the son of Allah'" uses *ibn* for "son."

remain from them" (Muqatil 2002, I, 494-5). At Q 5:76, Muqātil makes explicit his understanding that the ᶜĪsā the Christians serve (or worship, *taᶜbudūna*) instead of Allah has no power (*lā yamliku*) to cause them harm in the world or benefit them in the hereafter (I, 495).

Three centuries later, Abū al-Qāsim Maḥmūd ᶜUmar al-Zamakhsharī (d. 1143) knew at 5:17 that "it was said" Christians believed that ᶜĪsā creates, gives life, causes death, and manages (*dabbara*) the affairs of the world (Zamakhsharī 2006, I, 605). The verse's point about Allah's power to destroy the Messiah, he writes, is that the Messiah is not sovereign but rather merely a created servant no different from any other human. In the Quran ᶜĪsā says "I will create" (Q 3:49; cf. 5:110), but for Zamakhsharī ᶜĪsā's miracles "must be attributed to [Allah] and not to the human being through whom [Allah's] hand performs" (I, 605).

Interpretation of Q 5:72-77 provides Zamakhsharī with much more room to develop his ideas on the Quranic Messiah (I, 650-2), but specifically on sovereignty he starts with this Messiah's repudiation of his own Lordship in 5:72. Instead, ᶜĪsā tells the Children of Israel to worship Allah, the Lord (*rabb*). This means for the exegete an argument against the Christians, whom he characterizes as associating partners with Allah in worship, thereby denying themselves entry into Paradise. According to Zamakhsharī, ᶜĪsā will not help the Christians, "even though they magnified him [in the statement "Allah is the Messiah"] and raised his status" (I, 650).

"There is no god in existence except a god described by oneness (*wahadāniyya*), who has no second, and he is Allah alone, without partner," Zamakhsharī states at 5:73 (I, 650). He registers considerable astonishment and frustration that Christians persist in "straying from the truth," expanding the terms of 5:73-5 & 7. On the phrase "what has no power" in 5:76, Zamakhsharī writes, "[that] is ᶜĪsā" (I, 652). ᶜĪsā can neither harm nor benefit anyone as Allah can. "This is conclusive proof that his claim is contrary to Lordship (*rubūbiyya*, also "divinity," "deity," "godship")," he asserts. "The attribute of the Lord is to be capable of all things; nothing is beyond his power" (I, 652).

Zamakhsharī asks a rather remarkable question in the midst of his discussion of how all prophets are the same at 5:75. "So how did you become so confused about [ᶜĪsā and Maryam] that you described them in a way that was not used for any other prophet or companion?" (I, 601). Though Zamakhsharī immediately insists that "There is absolutely no difference or distinction between them and the prophets in any way," the question seems to be one that Paul – or many of

the early Christians – would have been pleased to answer in the case of Jesus. The early Christians included Jesus in the divine identity because they saw in him the attributes and actions of God. “We have seen his glory.”

5. Creational monotheism

The early Christian belief that Jesus was involved in creation follows closely on the understanding that Jesus possesses sovereignty over all things. Reading Isaiah 40-55, early Christians found divine sovereignty and creation activity indivisibly linked in such passages as Isaiah 45:18-25. They understood that Jesus’ sovereignty must be at work not only in the present but also from the beginning, including in God’s unique creative activity in the beginning. This belief is found in an early text from Paul (1 Cor 8:6; Bauckham 2018, 12) and in other texts spread throughout the New Testament (e.g. John, Colossians, Hebrews, Revelation).

Early Christians considered creating all things to be one of the key elements in God’s identity. They knew the questions of Isaiah 40:13, posed immediately following a picture of God as creator, “Who has directed the Spirit of YHWH, or as his counselor has instructed him” (cf. Isaiah 44:24). They agreed that God had no need of a helper outside himself. But just like they included Jesus in the divine sovereignty over all things, they included him also in the unique creative activity of God. “This was the early Christians’ Jewish way of preserving monotheism against the ditheism that any kind of adoptionist Christology was bound to involve” (Bauckham 2008, 185).

John is perhaps best known for the declaration at the start of his Gospel account that the divine Word was both God and with God, where all things came into being through the Word. By making this declaration John was connecting to a thoroughly Jewish tradition that God created the world through his Word (Ps. 33:6, cf. Hebrews 11:3; Bauckham 2018, 6).

1 Cor 8:6 is a good example of how Paul explained the same content of the divine identity of Jesus in creation, but in a different way. In the immediate context he affirms monotheism with the standard formula, “there is no God but one” (verse 4). Then in verse 6 Paul sets “one God, the Father” and “one Lord, Jesus Christ” together in parallel for a statement about creation. All

things are from the Father and we exist for him, Paul writes. All things are through Jesus Christ and we exist through him.

Paul does not call Jesus the "Word" in his assertion of Jesus' involvement in creation, but rather uses the *Shema*^{c}, which itself carries a concept of oneness: "The LORD our God is one LORD" (Deuteronomy 6:4). Paul provided a "carefully crafted reformulation" of the *Shema*^{c} to include in the one God "one God, the Father," and "one Lord, Jesus Christ" (Bauckham 2018, 11). In Bauckham's carefully-worded understanding of this reformulation, "the unique identity of the one God *consists of* the one God, the Father, *and* the one Lord, his Messiah (who is implicitly regarded as the Son of the Father)" (Bauckham 2008, p. 213). This was how Paul included Jesus in the divine identity of the one Creator God.

The language of "Word" and "Wisdom," however, was available among the resources in Second Temple Judaism for discourse about creation, and Bauckham insists that Paul was familiar with it. That language allowed a distinction "between God as the agent of creation and that through which or by which God created" (Bauckham 2008, 217). God's Word and/or God's Wisdom in this understanding is the instrumental cause of creation and was never other than God. Paul knew of this way of speaking about Jesus' identity but went straight for including Jesus in the divine identity, which meant that Jesus was a participant in creation. He used the differentiation within God that Jewish monotheism allowed with "Word" or "Wisdom," but found it in the *Shema*^{c} instead.

Quran and commentary

Christian readers of the Quran will likely hear a kind of echo of Isaiah 40:13 in some of the Quranic verses that deny that "Allah has taken a son." Q 2:116 opposes the expression by declaring that "Whatever is in the heavens and the earth [belongs] to him." But the next verse seems to put this response in a creation context: "Originator of the heavens and the earth. When he decrees something, he simply says to it, 'Be!' and it is" (2:117).

Another such verse with a creation connection is Q 23:91, "Allah has not taken a son, nor is there any god with him. Then each god would indeed have gone off with what he had created, and some of them would indeed have exalted (themselves) over others." The scenario seemingly

pictured by the verse is that if the "son" were a god, then Allah and the son would be in conflict and competition, each exalting himself over the other.

Muqātil connected the expression in 2:116 ("Allah has taken a son") with the Christians of Najrān, and in his interpretation of the verse distinguished Allah from ᶜĪsā and others as servants "under [Allah's] sovereignty (*fī mulkihi*)." At v. 117, the example Muqātil gives of Allah's creation is that he decreed that ᶜĪsā "come to be" in the womb of his mother without a father (Muqātil 2002, I, 133-4).

But a stronger Quranic challenge to the involvement of Jesus in the activity of creation comes in the rather categorical statement of Q 3:59 that Allah created Jesus himself in the womb of his mother: "Surely the likeness of ᶜĪsā is, with Allah, as the likeness of Adam. He created him from dust, then he said to him, 'Be!' and he was." At this verse, Muqātil tells the story of a meeting between Muhammad and the leaders of a Christian delegation said to come from Najrān in Yemen (Muqātil 2002, I, 279-82). The Christians engage Muhammad in a discussion about the identity of ᶜĪsā.

The spokesmen for the Najran Christians, "al-Sayyid and al-ᶜĀqib," immediately address Muhammad with the question, "Why do you abuse (*shatama*) and dishonor (*ᶜāba*) our master?" Muhammad asks, "What master of yours?" and the Christians explain. They speak about ᶜĪsā largely with Quranic vocabulary and ask Muhammad, "so show us in what Allah created a servant like him. He gives life to the dead and heals the blind and the leper and creates from clay a bird." Muqātil seems to add in parentheses that the Christians do not say "by permission of Allah" [which is the repeating refrain at Q 3:59 and 5:110].

"While every human has a father," the spokesmen continue, "ᶜĪsā had no father. So agree with us that ᶜĪsā is the son of Allah and we will follow you. You either take ᶜĪsā as a son or as a god." Muhammad answers, "Allah forbid that he should have a son or that there be with him a god." Eventually Muhammad refuses to answer further questions unless the Christians "submit" (or convert to Islam). The Christians claim, "We submitted prior to you," but Muhammad responds, "You two did not submit. Three things hold you back from islām: your eating of pork, your drinking of wine, and your saying that Allah, powerful and exalted, has a son." The frustrated Christians ask, "Who is the father of ᶜĪsā? Bring a likeness to him." According to Muqātil, this was the *sabab al-nuzūl* of Q 3:59 (I, 281; Nickel 2006, 175-8).

Sūra 3:59 constitutes one of the central arguments in the Quran against the deity of Christ, and many commentators have written extensively on this and the following verses (Ayoub II, 183-202). In his massive compendium of formative-period exegetical traditions, Ṭabarī presents seven traditions in addition to his own opinion on Q 3:59 (2005, III, 293-5). Most are versions of the story of Muhammad's meeting with the Najrān Christians, but they contain some differences to Muqātil's account.

In one tradition credited to al-Suddī, it is four men from Najrān who come to Muhammad. Muhammad tells them that ʻĪsā "is the servant of Allah, his spirit, and his word." The Christians object: "No! Rather, he is Allah. He descended from his kingdom (*mulkihi*), then entered into the interior of Maryam, then came out of her and showed us his power and his command! Have you ever seen a human being created without a father?" (III, 294).

Another wording of the conversation is credited to Ibn Jurayj. al-Sayyid and al-ᶜĀqib ask Muhammad, "Why do you abuse our master?" and Muhammad asks whom they mean. They say "'Īsā son of Maryam. You claim that he is a servant." Muhammad responds, "He is a servant of Allah and his word which he cast into Mary, and a spirit from him." The Najrān spokesmen become angry and say, "If you are truthful, then show us a servant who revives the dead, heals the blind, and creates from clay the likeness of a bird and breathes into it [and the rest of Q 3:49]. Rather, he is God" (III, 294).

A third tradition, offered on the authority of Ibn ʻAbbās, raises a very interesting question. In this version, when Muhammad tells the Najrān spokesmen that ʻĪsā is "the servant of Allah," they ask, "Have you seen the likeness of Jesus, or have you been informed of him?" (III, 293). This appears to be an attempt of the Christians to tell Muhammad information about Jesus that he does not know.

Curiously, in none of these traditions does Muhammad himself answer the questions about Jesus' identity confidently. In three of the traditions Allah simply reveals Q 3:59 immediately after the Christians question Muhammad. But in two of the traditions Gabriel has a role in bringing the verse. In one of those, Muhammad remains silent for a time after hearing the Christians' questions, then recites Q 5:17 & 72 while he waits for Gabriel to come. Finally Muhammad asks Gabriel for help with the "likeness of Jesus" question (III, 294).

The scenario of multiple gods imagined at Q 23:91, if this is indeed a characterization of Christian belief about Son of God, deserves a response. First, there were no extra gods in Paul's Christology of divine identity. Rather, simply one God the Father and one Lord Jesus Christ. Second, in New Testament teaching about Father and Son, there is no competition with one exalting himself over the other. Instead, Paul's portrayal of Jesus' downward journey in Phil 2 shows the obedience of the Son to the Father. And elsewhere in the New Testament, the relationship between the Father and the Son is obedience and love (e.g., John 5:19-30, 3:35, 10:17).

In the New Testament, the Word of God is not an assistant (*sharīk* or *walī*) to God in the work of creating, but rather is included in the relationship with God as the instrumental cause of creation (Bauckham 2008, 214, 194). The term "word" (*kalima*) does appear in the Quran in its characterization of ᶜĪsā (3:45, 4:171), but Islamic *tafsīr* has not permitted this to go beyond the "word" of Allah's command "Be!" in Allah's creation of all things, including of ᶜĪsā. It was not always this simple in Islamic thought, however.

At the end of the second Islamic century, a crisis developed among Muslim scholars over calling the Quran the "Word of Allah." Scholars disagreed about whether the Quran should be thought of as created or uncreated. Traditionalists scholars argued that since the Quran was the Word of Allah, it could not be said to be separate from Allah. Therefore they decided that the Quran must have been with Allah from the beginning – pre-existent and eternal. For a time, the view that the Quran was created was enforced in the Muslim Empire by the ᶜAbbāsid caliph al-Ma'mūn (r. 813-33). However, it was the opposing view of the traditionist Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal (d. 855) which eventually became the orthodox position on this question.

This orthodox Muslim position on the status of the Quran has been described as "inlibration"—or "embookment"—by Harry Wolfson, in deliberate comparison to the Christian belief in Incarnation. Traditionists believed the Quran to be the pre-existent, uncreated Word of God, Wolfson explained. In this view the Qur'ān existed from eternity as an attribute of God; at a second stage it came onto the "preserved tablet" mentioned in Q 85:21-2. The transition from the first state to the second was conceived of as "some kind of act whereby the Word would not cease to be an uncreated attribute in God." (Wolfson 1976, 246-8; cf. Seale 1964, 66-9, 103-112).

The Quran and its commentators placed ʿĪsā determinately on the human side of the divine/human divide. Paul dealt quite freely with this six hundred years earlier when he wrote that Christ Jesus, "though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men" (Phil 2:5-7).

6. Cultic monotheism

The early Christians worshipped Jesus because they recognized his divine sovereignty and understood him to have the divine name YHWH. In Philippians 2:9-11, Paul declared God's exaltation of Jesus, his bestowal of "the name that is above every name" on Jesus, the bending of every knee before Jesus, and the confession of every tongue that "Jesus Christ is Lord." Bauckham insists that for every Jewish writer of the Second Temple period, "the name which is above every name" (Phil 2:9) could not be any name other that YHWH (2008, 199).

The worship of Jesus was both widespread and early among the first Christians (Bauckham 2008, 199). The early Christians studied Isaiah 40-55 as a kind of code book to decipher what they had seen and heard in Jesus. Paul's words in Phil 2:10, "every knee should bow," of course echo Isaiah 45:23, but his "kenosis" passage may be seen against the much wider canvas of deutero-Isaiah.

Paul declared the exaltation of Jesus not on the basis of Psalm 110:1 but rather on the basis of his reading of Isaiah 52:13, "See, my servant shall prosper; he shall be exalted and lifted up, and shall be very high." Basing the worship of Jesus on these passages was a profoundly Jewish way of coming at the deity of Jesus through the Hebrew Bible and Second Temple Jewish monotheistic discourse rather than in the terms of Greek thought or any other kind of worldview. Paul wanted to present the worship of Jesus in the terms of "the exclusive monotheistic worship of the Jewish religious tradition" (Bauckham 2008, 201). Contrary to the characterization of Paul and the followers of ʿĪsā and Paul in Islamic tradition, the early Christians wrote about Jesus from within the Jewish monotheistic context, not rejecting that context but identifying Jesus according to its terms. Paul was a part of this community, not an enemy who wanted to pervert Christians so they would go to hell.

Isaiah 52:13 in turn directly precedes the "Servant Song" that most vividly portrays the suffering of the Servant. According to Phil 2, God exalted Jesus to the position where he is worthy of worship because ("therefore," Phil 2:9) he humbled himself, was obedient to God the Father, suffered and died. This compares well to the "therefore" of Isaiah 53:12 after the "anguish" of the Servant in 53:3-10.

The terms of Paul's description of Christ's journey from emptying himself to exaltation are similar to those of the scene in Revelation 5 in which "a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain" (Rev 5:6) is found worthy to open the scrolls and is subsequently worshipped by "every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea" (5:13). They sing, "You are worthy..., for you were slaughtered and by your blood you ransomed for God saints from every tribe and language and people and nation" (5:9).

This early Christian worship of Jesus was not a contradiction of the worship of God, as Quranic verses such as 5:17, 72, and 9:31 seem to suggest. Rather, it was a recognition that worship of Jesus is worship of God. Jesus was worshipped not as a competitive object of worship or as an alternative to God the Father ("besides," "apart from," "instead of," *min dūn* in Quranic language) but rather, as Phil 2 states, "to the glory of God the Father" (2:11).

"He is worshipped, because he participates in the unique divine sovereignty and bears the name that names the unique divine identity. Since he does so as the Son of his Father, sharing, not rivalling or usurping, his Father's sovereignty, worship of Jesus is also worship of his Father, but it is nonetheless really worship of Jesus" (Bauckham 2008, 202-3; cf. 147).

Quran and commentary

The Quran shows an active concern that no one or nothing be worshipped instead of Allah. Three texts from the Quran serve to indicate the various dimensions of this concern. Q 3:64 summons the "People of the Book" to agree with the commitment that "We do not worship [anyone] but Allah, and do not associate [anything] with him, and do not take each other as Lords instead of Allah."

ᶜĪsā himself weighs in on the subject of worship in Q 5:116 when Allah asks ᶜĪsā whether he told the people to take him and his mother "as two gods instead of Allah." His answer to Allah includes "I only said to them what you commanded me, 'Worship Allah, my Lord and your

Lord'" (5:117). This is one of a series of verses in which the Quran "quotes" ᶜĪsā as denying his own deity (Q 3:51, 5:72, 19:36, 43:64; cf. 4:172).

A third text on worship, and perhaps the most emphatic, is Q 9:31. The previous verse greets the Christian confession, "The Messiah is the son of Allah," with the exclamations, "Allah fight them! How are they [so] deluded?" (9:30). Immediately after this, the Quran states, "They have taken their teachers and their monks as Lords instead of Allah, and the Messiah, son of Mary, when they were only commanded to worship[3] one God. [There is] no god but him. Glory to him above what they associate" (9:31).

While the second and third of the passages are explicit that the "unbelievers" who do these things are Christians, the first (3:64) is not explicit, but the preceding context strongly suggests that this is about Christians and their beliefs about ᶜĪsā. This is indeed how many exegetes understood the verse (Ayoub 1992, 202-8; Nickel 2009a, 176-84). Muqātil treated the verse as a continuation of the story about Muhammad's *mubāhala* with the Najrān Christians, and interpreted "if they turn away" as "if they reject *tawhīd*" (Muqātil 2002, I, 281).

These three verses gather several angles of the denial of ᶜĪsā's deity in the Quran: Do not worship him, do not take him as Lord, do not associate ᶜĪsā with Allah by calling him son of Allah or putting him together with Allah in the Trinity. Rāzī wrote about Q 3:64, "They worship someone other than Allah, that is the Messiah. They associate others with him, and that is because they say that Allah is three" (Rāzī 1973, VIII, 86). Rāzī also showed familiarity with the terminology of "divine personalities" (*dhawāt*) and "hypostasis" (*uqnūm*) at 3:64, and characterized Christians as believing that "the Word armed itself (*tadarraᶜa*) in the humanity of the Messiah." His judgment was that "they committed *shirk*."

Rāzī, "the intellectual diamond cutter" of Muslim exegetes in the admiration of Norman Calder (1993, 114), offered a great deal of theological and christological content in his commentary on verses like Q 3:64. And beyond treating the theological points with appropriate seriousness, he

[3] The word translated "worship" in these verses (*naᶜbuda*, *aᶜbudū*, *yaᶜbudū*) is also rendered as "serve" in some English translations because the Arabic verb can go both ways. Muslim commentaries may give an idea of the sense that exegetes understood.

also envisioned a kind of personal engagement with Christians whose beliefs he opposed (e.g., VIII, 85-6,). On the beginning of the third Sūra, for example, Rāzī lists the kind of questions he says Muhammad asks Christians, among them, "Do you not know that our Lord has control over everything which he alone preserves and sustains? Does Jesus possess the power to do any of these things?" (VII, 155). In his comments on Q 3:61, he tells a story of a discussion he had with a Christian in Khwārizm. When the Christian confesses Jesus as God, Rāzī replies that "Allah is a non-contingent existent in himself" in contrast to 'Īsā, a "human corporeal person." He concludes, "It is stipulated in the self-evident truths of reason (*badā'ih al-ᶜaqūl*) that anyone who voids (*muḥdith*) could not be eternal" (VIII, 78).

Rāzī's idea of a "just" or even "fair" encounter, therefore, did not mean sparing the feelings of Christian interlocutors about the deity and redemptive death of Jesus. "On what basis do you infer the deity of ᶜĪsā?" Rāzī asks the Christian. The Christian replies, on the basis of ᶜĪsā's miracles, which he lists from Q 3:49. Rāzī quips that Moses' miracle of turning a stick into a snake is a greater miracle, so Moses is more deserving than ᶜĪsā of being God or the son of God – "yet no one has asserted this of [Moses]." (III, 79-80).

In his comments on Q 9:29, Rāzī returned to his disagreement with Christian confessions: their beliefs in Father, Son and Holy Spirit, in Incarnation (*ḥulūl*) and "merged oneness" (*ittiḥād*), "by which they negate deity" (XVI, 28). By confessing such beliefs, plus their belief that the hypostasis (*uqnūm*) of the word (*kalima*) incarnated in ᶜĪsā, Rāzī alleges, Christians show that they do not believe in Allah at all! Further along in the verse, Rāzī appears to suggest that it was this false Christology of the Christians – and no other reason – which made them deserving of Muslim attack "until they pay the tribute readily, having been humbled" [Q 9:29]. Quoting Zamakhsharī, Rāzī writes that this was actually a benefaction: "accepting the jizyah from them and sparing their lives is a great blessing (*niᶜma ᶜaẓīma*) for them" (XVI, 19-30).

There is a great deal of similar material in the vast Islamic interpretive tradition, largely unprocessed in formal Christian-Muslim dialogue. The *tafsīr* excerpts described above are just the tip of an iceberg.

The harshness of Rāzī's interpretation of Q 9:29, however, deserves scholarly inquiry. Strong feeling accompanies many passages of the Quran that seem to refer to the deity of Jesus. From the "What if Allah wished to destroy the Messiah?" of Q 5:17 to the "Fire" for one who

"associates" in 5:72 to the "painful punishment" on those who say "three" in 5:73 to the "see how deluded they are" of 5:75, the expression "Allah is the Messiah" drew vigorous responses. Q 9:30 exclaims "Allah fight them!" at Christians who say "The Messiah is the son of God" (this verse sitting between "Fight those...who have been given the Book" of 9:29 and "prevail over all religion" at 9:33). And these were not the most extreme: Q 19:88-92 calls the statement "Raḥmān has taken a son" "abhorrent" then says "The heavens are nearly torn apart because of it, and the earth split open, and the mountains collapse in pieces" (19:90).

What would account for this strong feeling – significantly stronger than that shown in the Quran about many other human beliefs or actions? Accusations of wrong thinking and false faith is one thing. But the universe will explode? And so different from the delight that Paul and New Testament writers take in "Son of God" writing in the context of Second Temple Jewish monotheism (Hengel 1976, 7-15; Hurtado 2003, 101-8; cf. Acts 9:20). The scholarship on why early Christians called Jesus the Son of God, and its background in the Hebrew Bible, is deep and thorough. Could one say the same for the scholarship on why this name was found so abhorrent in Quran and *tafsīr*? This topic deserves more attention in the academy.

If we could imagine Paul appearing among those early Muslims who established Islamic orthodoxy to discuss theology, or perhaps calling on Rāzī in Kwarazim, could he have found a way to make a case for a Christology of divine identity from the *tawḥīd* of the Quran? Or would strong feelings, and the up till now seemingly opaque reasons behind those feelings, simply prevent him from getting a hearing?

7. Further Pauline christological affirmations that respond to Islamic objections

Reading Bauckham's presentation of Pauline thought in the previous sections stimulates many further thoughts about the identity of God with Islam in mind. Much of the language Bauckham uses to describe the first century Christology of divine identity seems to respond to Quranic characterizations of Christian faith in the seventh century (however, with no evident intention to do so).

1. Early Christians did not somehow "add" Jesus to God but rather understood Jesus to be "included" in the unique identity of the one God (2008, 209). Paul did not add "one Lord" to the

"one God" of the *Shemaʿ*, but used that famous confession itself to include Jesus in the unique identity of the one Creator (2008, 209, 212-13). Their faith was not a ditheism ("two gods"), but rather affirmation of monotheism (2008, 185, 196). Paul does not introduce an "associate" to God who is not God himself (2008, 218).

2. Paul used the name YHWH to refer to Jesus much more frequently than he used the word "God." In Jewish monotheism, YHWH names the unique divine identity. Bauckham suggests that the name YHWH "is exclusive to the one God in a way that the sometimes ambiguous word 'god' is not" (2008, 200; cf. 2018, 13). He asserts that "It is much more significant that Paul can take texts referring to YHWH as references to Jesus" (2018, 13). When John uses the name God for Jesus, he is also careful and deliberate, using it at significant points (John 1:1; 20:28) (2018, 15).

3. Many of the passages that argue against the deity of Jesus in the Quran include an explicit monotheistic formula in the verse itself or in the near context (e.g. Q 5:72f.; cf. Cuypers 2009, 338). Similarly, many of the passages from the Hebrew Bible most frequently used by Paul and the early Christians to account for Jesus' identity contain focused monotheistic assertions (e.g. Joel 2:27, Isaiah 45:18; cf. Bauckham 2008, 191-6, 201). When Paul presents the deity of Jesus, he also includes recognizable monotheistic affirmations (e.g. Rom 10:12, 1 Cor 8:4).

4. The New Testament indicates concepts of oneness that may not match the developed Islamic doctrine of *tawḥīd*. In the Gospel according to John, Jesus says, "I and the Father are one" (10:30; cf. 17:11, 22). Jesus is not saying that he and the Father a single person, argues Bauckham, but rather that together they are one God (2008, 104). Bauckham describes Jesus' words as an allusion to the *Shemaʿ*, just as he also recognized the famous Jewish confession in 1 Cor 8:6 (above). "The Johannine Jesus' claim to oneness with the Father amounts to including himself in the unique identity of the one God as understood in Jewish monotheism," Bauckham writes. "Within this divine identity, there is the uniquely intimate relationship of the Father and the Son" (2008, 105). The oneness of Jesus' claim is the oneness of unity and "community" rather than the oneness of uniqueness (Bauckham 2015, 32-4). This Christology steps outside of the categories of "Jewish monotheistic definition of the unique identity of the one God," but Bauckham argues that Jewish monotheism does not deny or contradict any of these categories (2007, 251). "Exclusive devotion is now given to Jesus, but Jesus does not thereby replace or

comete with God the Father, since he himself belongs to the unique divine identity" (Bauckham 2008, 106).

5. Following closely on the previous point, Paul and the New Testament are actually more "binatarian" than trinitarian. That is, there is much more material connecting the Lord Jesus Christ with God the Father than there is about connecting to the Spirit (Bauckham 2015, 36; cf. 2018, 16). The terms "Father" and "Son" entail each other. "So to say that Jesus and the Father are one is to say that the unique divine identity comprises the relationship in which the Father is who he is only in relation to the Son, and vice versa" (Bauckham, 2007, 251).

8. Dualling monotheisms?

Traditional Muslim criticism of Paul centres on the accusation that he perverted an original monotheism held by the early followers of ᶜĪsā. The alleged monotheism of these *hawāriyyūn* is portrayed as the Islamic concept of monotheism, in line with the Muslim doctrine that ᶜĪsā was a prophet and messenger very like Muhammad (and indeed in line with what ᶜĪsā says about himself in the Quran). Bauckham's research in the literature of Second Temple Judaism shows that Paul and the other New Testament writers certainly wrote out of a strict monotheistic context, a monotheism that they shared. But within that context, they came to include Jesus in the divine identity of the one God.

This invites enquiry into the question of the possible differences between these respective monotheisms. Though Second Temple Judaism was unquestionably monotheistic, was it the same monotheism as the developed Islamic doctrine of *tawḥīd*?

"YHWH our God is one YHWH." The statement is followed by a command to Israel to love YHWH with heart, soul and might (Deut 6:5). Paul was able to find in that oneness the inclusion and differentiation of one God, the Father, and one Lord, Jesus Christ.

"He is Allah, one" (Q 112:1). This statement is followed by a *hapax legomenon*, *ṣamad*, the meaning of which has challenged interpreters ever since (Paret 1979, 294-5; Schedl 1981, 2-4; Rubin 1984, 206-7). And the Quran contains no command to humans to love Allah (Nickel 2009b, 235).

Are these monotheisms the same? One of the aspects of this question is the concept of distinction within the one God. For example, Bauckham writes that the Jewish language and conceptuality of creation left room for Paul to think of Jesus as the instrumental cause of creation through the concepts of God's Word and God's Wisdom (2008, 217-18). These personified or hypostatized divine aspects are not created beings but are presented in the Hebrew Bible as intrinsic to God's own identity. "The Second Temple Jewish understanding of the divine uniqueness does not define it as unitariness and does not make distinctions within the divine identity inconceivable" (Bauckham 2008, 17).

The introduction to the Gospel according to John therefore presents the Word as God but also "with God," both identification and differentiation (2018, 14-15). Paul did not use the avenue of the "Word" in his differentiation of God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ in 1 Cor 8:6. He went straight for inclusion of Jesus in the divine identity. But he certainly found in the Jewish texts on creation "a distinction within the divine relationship to creation" (2008, 218). He did this without introducing an associate other than God or making Jesus a second God (2018, 12).

The possibility of differentiation within the Quranic Allah would seem to be prohibited by Islamic interpretations of the descriptor *ṣamad*, (Q 112:2), for example Muqātil's says one who "has no cavity (*lā jawf lahu*, also "hollow," "interior," "centre") like the cavity of created beings" (Muqātil 2002, IV, 916). Modern Muslim translations render the word as the one who supplies all needs but has no needs.

Another aspect of this question is the evident freedom in the Hebrew Bible and Second Temple Jewish literature to describe God by the analogy of human personal identity (Bauckham 2008, 6). Though the Quran contains some anthropomorphism in its references to Allah, Orthodox Islam chose largely not to go in this direction, showing a marked dislike for metaphor and anthropomorphic expressions. There is therefore a wealth of description of the identity of God in the Bible which cannot be assumed in the theology of the Quran. This difference surely affects the freedom to think of God's Word appearing in human flesh (John 1:14).

These thoughts qualify the Islamic accusation against Paul that he was perverting monotheism. The question becomes "Whose monotheism?" To what extent is the Muslim misunderstanding of Paul and his writings a product a lack of appreciation for differences in concepts of monotheism? Does the monotheism represented in the Islamic doctrine of *tawḥīd* "prevail over" (Q 9:33,

48:28, 61:9) and cancel out all other concepts? This question deserves much more attention, not only for the benefits it may bring to Christian-Muslim dialogue, but simply as a worthwhile contribution to academic knowledge.

9. Paul's Christology of divine identity and monotheism

The early Christians attempted, in the context of Second Temple Jewish monotheism, to comprehend and express what they had seen and/or heard about Jesus – his life, teaching, miracles, compassion, suffering and death, resurrection and ascension. Paul, who called himself "one untimely born" and "the least of the apostles" (1 Cor 15:9-10) was compelled to address the risen Christ as "Lord" and immediately began to proclaim Jesus as the Son of God (Acts 9: 5, 20). In the monotheistic context in which he was raised and educated – the strictest monotheism of his age – he preached and wrote that Jesus was included in the divine identity. Not a second god, not an associate of God who was other than God, but rather a participant with God the Father in the divine work of creation and sovereign rule.

Might thoroughly peer-reviewed academic scholarship on first-century Christian monotheism like that of Richard Bauckham create some space in Christian-Muslim dialogue to converse about Paul's presentation of the deity of Jesus as other than a repudiation of monotheism? Or would it merely draw the dull repetition of Quranic verses and medieval Muslim caricatures of Paul? Could it encourage Muslim scholars to read the writings of Paul himself and to respond in even temper, as happened with the dearly-departed Shabbir Akhtar? Akhtar, who famously dismissed ᶜAbd al-Jabbār, Ibn Ḥazm, and Sayyid Quṭb on Paul, went so far as to familiarize himself with the Greek text of Galatians and the Hebrew text of Paul's quotations from the Hebrew Bible (2018; cf. Nickel 2019). May many others follow in his path.

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